

BETTER VICE CLUB

Learn.WitUS Curriculum

CentenarianOS Academy

Episode 3

Chocolate

"The Food of the Gods"

Social Studies

Teacher Curriculum Packet

Pilot Edition | 2026-2027

How Better Vice Club Works

Better Vice Club (BVC) is a podcast curriculum that teaches Geography, Social Studies, Economics, and English Language Arts through global commodities. Each episode follows a single substance from its geographic origin through its history, economics, and the literature it has generated. Your packet isolates your subject so you can use it standalone, or coordinate with other departments for a full interdisciplinary unit.

What You Need

- Episode audio linked on the Episode Overview page. Episodes run 35 to 40 minutes. You can use the full episode or specific segments called CUT POINTS.
- This packet. All student-facing materials are here, ready to print or share digitally.
- No additional materials required for core activities.

CUT POINTS

Each episode is divided into labeled segments. You don't need to play the full episode. CUT-3D is the Economics segment; CUT-3E is ELA, and so on. Start times are on the Episode Overview page.

The Four BVC Patterns

These patterns repeat across all three seasons of BVC covering 21 episodes:

- Geography Insists. The physical landscape determines what can grow and how.
- Cultivation Begins Sacred. Most commodities begin as ceremonial practice before they become commercial products.
- Labor Captures the Smallest Share. Producers earn the least. Brands and retailers earn the most.
- What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved. Who controls the narrative about a commodity shapes its history.

BVC is produced by Anthony McDonald in Indianapolis, Indiana. All content is documented with peer-reviewed APA citations. No fabricated stories or unnamed expert characters appear in any episode. The curriculum brand is Learn.WitUS, hosted at CentenarianOS.com/academy.

Episode 3 Overview: Chocolate

Detail	Information
Episode title	The Food of the Gods
Season	Season 1: Daily Rituals
Full runtime	35 to 40 minutes
Subjects	Geography, Social Studies, Economics, ELA (all four in one episode)
Audio access	CentenarianOS.com/academy or ask your BVC contact for the file
Recommended grade	9 to 12 (Indiana Academic Standards aligned)

Segment Map

Use CUT POINTS to navigate directly to your subject without playing the full episode.

Cut ID	Segment Title	Start Time	Duration	Subject
CUT-3A	Cold Open: The Price of Gods	0:00	2 min	All subjects
CUT-3B	The Cacao Belt	2:00	8 min	Geography
CUT-3C	From Sacred Drink to Slave Trade	10:00	8 min	Social Studies
CUT-3D	The \$161 Billion Bar	18:00	8 min	Economics
CUT-3E	The Gods Write Back	26:00	8 min	ELA
CUT-3F	The Conscious Bar (Closing)	34:00	2 min	All subjects

Episode Summary

Episode 3 follows cacao from Mayan ceremonial centers in Mesoamerica, where it was currency and sacred drink, through the colonial plantation economy that moved production to West Africa, to a \$161.5 billion global industry where Ivory Coast farmers earn less than \$1 per day. The episode asks why the people who grow chocolate have never tasted it.

Cross-curricular note: If colleagues in other departments are also piloting BVC, their students are studying the same episode through different lenses. Episode 3 connects directly to Episode 1 (Coffee) and Episode 4 (Sugar) as part of a three-episode arc on colonial commodities.

Social Studies Vocabulary

Introduce these terms before the Social Studies segment (CUT-3C, starting at 10:00).

Term	Definition	Episode Connection
Xocolatl	Aztec word for the bitter cacao drink. Ancestor of the word chocolate.	The original sacred drink before sugar and colonization transformed it.
Theobroma	Greek for 'food of the gods.' The scientific genus name for cacao.	European scientists acknowledged the plant's sacred status even while commercializing it.
Florentine Codex	A 16th century document compiled by Spanish friar Bernardino de Sahagun containing Aztec accounts of their culture, including chocolate.	One of the few primary sources documenting Aztec chocolate ceremonies from the Aztec perspective.
Cultural erasure	The deliberate or systematic destruction of a culture's practices, knowledge, or records.	The burning of Maya codices destroyed most records of cacao ceremonies. Only four Maya codices survive.
Plantation system	Large-scale agricultural production using coerced or enslaved labor on a single crop, owned by a colonial power.	European colonial powers moved cacao production to West African plantations using enslaved labor.
Sacred-to-commercial pattern	BVC term for the consistent historical pattern where substances begin as ceremonial practice and are later commercialized, typically through colonialism.	Cacao follows this pattern from Maya ceremony to a Cadbury bar.

Child labor (in context)	The use of children in work that denies them childhood and schooling, often in dangerous conditions. 1.56 million children work in West African cacao.	Modern consequence of the colonial extraction system: poverty-level farmer incomes make child labor economically rational for struggling families.
Codex	Plural: codices. A hand-written book from ancient or medieval times. Maya and Aztec codices recorded history, astronomy, religion, and cultural practices.	Spanish colonizers burned most Mesoamerican codices. Only four Maya codices and a handful of Aztec documents survive.

Social Studies Data Sheet: From Sacred Drink to Global Industry

Timeline: Cacao from Sacred to Commercial

Date	Event	Significance
c. 600 CE	Maya use cacao in religious ceremonies and as currency in Mesoamerica	Cacao begins as sacred and ceremonial. The Maya word for cacao appears in hieroglyphic records at this time.
c. 1345 CE	Aztec empire makes cacao a tribute item; cacao beans serve as currency	One turkey = 100 cacao beans. Cacao has measurable economic value within a sacred system.
1519 CE	Spanish conquistador Hernan Cortes arrives in Tenochtitlan and encounters chocolate	Emperor Montezuma reportedly drank 50 cups of xocolatl per day. Cortes writes about it to King Charles V.
1521 CE	Spanish conquest of Tenochtitlan. Most Aztec codices burned.	Only four Maya codices survive from pre-colonial Mesoamerica. The written record of cacao ceremony is nearly destroyed.
1600s CE	Spanish colonizers add sugar; hot chocolate becomes a European elite drink	Transformation complete: bitter sacred drink becomes sweet European luxury. Processing moves to Europe.
1700s CE	Cacao plantation system established in West Africa using enslaved labor	The crop follows the same labor system as sugar. West Africa becomes the production center without any cultural connection to cacao.

1828 CE	Coenraad Van Houten patents the cocoa press in the Netherlands	Industrial processing begins. Chocolate becomes separable into cocoa powder and cocoa butter, enabling mass production.
1847 CE	JS Fry and Sons creates the first solid chocolate bar in Britain	Chocolate transitions from drink to food. The modern chocolate industry begins.
1875 CE	Daniel Peter adds milk to create milk chocolate using Henri Nestle's condensed milk	Mass-market chocolate becomes possible. Cadbury, Rowntree, and Hershey follow.
2020 CE	1.56 million children work in West African cacao (International Labour Organization)	The colonial extraction system's legacy: poverty-level farmer incomes create economic pressure to use child labor.

Primary Source: Florentine Codex on Cacao (c. 1570)

Friar Bernardino de Sahagun compiled accounts from Aztec informants in the Florentine Codex, documenting Aztec culture after the conquest. On cacao:

"He who sells cacao... grinds it, pulverizes it, separates it. He makes cacao with water; he makes it frothy, he aerates it, he fills it, he strains it, he stirs it. He sells it with ground maize, with ground seeds, with chile, with water, with nothing...

Green cacao: poisonous, dangerous, not to be drunk... He who drinks too much of it, it harms him, makes him dizzy, confuses him, makes him sick."

-- Florentine Codex, Book 10, c. 1570

Context: The Codex documents cacao as a sophisticated, regulated product with known quality distinctions, preparation methods, and risks. It wasn't a drink for everyone. This is among the few surviving primary sources with an Indigenous perspective on cacao.

Primary Source: Hernan Cortes to King Charles V of Spain (1519)

"The great Moctezuma... was served a drink made of cacao that was said to give wisdom and vigor to those who drink it, and always after dinner a great quantity of it was brought to him in cups of finest gold. He was served with more than fifty great jars of good cacao frothed up, and he drank of it."

-- Hernan Cortes, Second Letter to Charles V, 1519

Context: Cortes frames chocolate through gold, royalty, and power. His description sparks European elite interest in the drink. He doesn't mention the ceremonial or community meaning of cacao in Aztec life.

The burning of codices: When Spanish colonizers destroyed Maya and Aztec written records, they destroyed most primary source evidence for how cacao was governed and used ceremonially. Of thousands of pre-colonial Mesoamerican books, only four Maya codices survive. BVC Pattern 4 (What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved) applies directly here. The absence of those records made it easier for colonial narratives about 'primitive' Indigenous cultures to go unchallenged.

Social Studies Activity: Sacred vs. Commercial

Time: 35 to 40 minutes. Materials: this packet plus the two primary source excerpts above.

Step 1: Two Texts, Same Substance (10 minutes)

Students read both primary source excerpts. For each:

- Who wrote this? What's their relationship to cacao?
- What does the document reveal about how the writer's culture understands cacao?
- What does each document NOT mention that the other does?

Key comparison: The Florentine Codex reflects an Aztec perspective describing regulation, ceremony, and social meaning. Cortes's letter reflects a colonizer's perspective describing value, power, and exoticism. Same substance. Radically different frames.

Step 2: The Sacred-to-Commercial Pattern (10 minutes)

Using the timeline, students trace the four stages of the pattern for cacao:

- Stage 1 (Indigenous sacred use): What was cacao's cultural role before European contact?
- Stage 2 (Colonial contact and transformation): How did Spanish colonizers change what cacao meant and who controlled it?
- Stage 3 (Commercial scaling): How did 19th century industrialization transform cacao into a mass commodity?
- Stage 4 (Modern extraction): What does the \$161.5 billion global chocolate industry look like today compared to Aztec cacao governance?

Step 3: Codex Burning and Narrative Control (10 minutes)

- The Aztec regulatory system for cacao was sophisticated: cacao was restricted to specific social groups and governed by ceremonial protocol. When codices were burned, this evidence was destroyed. Who benefits when those records don't

exist? How does the absence affect the historical narrative about Indigenous Mesoamerican sophistication?

- Modern chocolate brands sometimes use Maya or Aztec imagery in their marketing. Does that marketing acknowledge the communities it references? What would genuine acknowledgment look like economically?

Discussion Questions

- The Florentine Codex was compiled by a Spanish friar using Aztec informants. Is it an Aztec primary source, a Spanish primary source, or something in between? How does authorship affect how we read historical documents?
- 1.56 million children work in West African cacao. Is this a moral failure by individual companies, a structural failure of the global commodity system, or both? What evidence supports your position?

Social Studies Knowledge Checks

Use as an exit ticket, short quiz, or discussion prompt. Answer key follows.

1. What was cacao's cultural role in Aztec society before European contact? Use at least one specific detail from the timeline or primary sources.

2. The burning of Maya and Aztec codices destroyed most primary sources on cacao ceremony. Using BVC's Pattern 4 (What Gets Burned, What Gets Saved), explain who benefits when those records don't exist and how their absence shapes our understanding of pre-colonial Mesoamerican civilization.

3. 1.56 million children work in West African cacao production (ILO, 2020). Using the timeline and supply chain data, explain why this is happening as a structural problem connected to colonial history, not simply individual moral failure.

Answer Key (teacher reference only)

Q1 expected answer:

Cacao in Aztec society was: sacred (associated with rain deity Tlaloc and other gods), reserved for elites (warriors, merchants, nobility), used as currency (1 turkey = 100 cacao beans), and governed by social protocol. Students should cite at least one specific detail: the currency exchange rate, the restriction to elite use, the 50 cups attributed to Montezuma, or the ritual preparation in the Florentine Codex.

Q2 expected answer:

When codices are burned: (1) evidence of sophisticated Aztec governance systems is erased, making it easier for colonizers to narrate Indigenous cultures as 'primitive' or without law; (2) intellectual achievements can't be compared to European ones on equal terms; (3) the people who destroyed the records benefit most from the narrative that nothing of comparable value was lost. The absence of records didn't mean the absence of sophistication.

Q3 expected answer:

Structural explanation: (1) Colonial powers established West African cacao production as a low-cost export commodity; (2) post-colonial farmers inherited that low-value position in the supply chain at \$0.45 to \$0.84 per day; (3) at those income levels, families depend on all household labor including children for survival; (4) companies capturing 60 to 75 percent of the chocolate bar's final price haven't raised farmer prices proportionally. Individual company choices matter, but the structural conditions that make child labor economically rational were created by colonial trade architecture.

Indiana Social Studies Standards Alignment

Standard	Description	Where Addressed
WH.4.1	Analyze causes and effects of European colonialism	Spanish conquest; codex burning; plantation establishment in West Africa
WH.4.3	Evaluate the impact of the Transatlantic Slave Trade	West African cacao plantation labor system; colonial commodity extraction
WH.3.2	Analyze how indigenous cultures developed before European contact	Maya and Aztec cacao ceremony; Florentine Codex as primary source
C&G.2.1	Analyze how economic interests shape government policy	Colonial governance of cacao trade; modern policy failures on child labor
WH.5.4	Evaluate how globalization affects cultural and economic systems	Sacred Maya/Aztec practice vs. \$161B global industry; child labor as globalization consequence

Reviewer's Feedback Form

Your feedback directly shapes the Learn.WitUS curriculum. Please complete this form after using the materials with students.

DIGITAL VERSION: Scan the QR code below or visit the link provided by your BVC contact. Responses feed directly into a shared spreadsheet for curriculum improvement.

[QR CODE]

About You

1. Subject you teach:

2. Grade level(s) in this pilot:

3. Approximate number of students who used this material:

About the Materials

4. Which segment(s) or activities did you use?

5. Did students have sufficient background knowledge to engage? What was missing or what helped?

6. Were the Indiana Standards alignments accurate for how you teach this standard?

Student Engagement

7. Scale 1 to 5: How well did the episode hold student attention? (1 = struggled, 5 = highly engaged.) Notes:

8. What specific activity or discussion moment generated the most student response?

Usability

9. Would you use this as a standalone lesson, a unit anchor, or a recurring series? Why?

10. The single change that would make this most usable in your classroom next year:

Overall

11. Would you recommend this curriculum to a colleague? What would you say?

Responses are confidential and used only to improve Learn.WitUS curriculum. Thank you for your time and expertise. Anthony McDonald, Better Vice Club